The Relational Self Framework

A Conceptual Whitepaper on Self-Modeling, Interpersonal Reflection, and Psychological Growth

Prepared from concepts developed in dialogue with the author

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Executive Summary

This whitepaper presents the **Relational Self Framework**, a conceptual model of selfhood organized around two central ideas.

First, the self is not exhausted by a single inner essence or a single self-description. It is better understood as a structured relation among lived experience, conscious self-recognition, unintegrated or shadow material, aspiration, self-image, and social presentation.

Second, self-knowledge is not generated only through introspection. It also develops **relationally**, through the duality of perspectives that emerges when two people perceive one another. This relational process produces both misrecognition and insight. It can reveal disowned parts of the self, clarify aspirations, and expose gaps between the self-image and lived reality.

The framework is designed to be rigorous, accessible, and useful as a conceptual contribution to contemporary psychology. It integrates familiar psychological themes—self-concept, self-discrepancy, projection, reflected appraisal, and interpersonal feedback—into a single architecture. It does **not** present itself as a clinical protocol or a substitute for validated therapies. Rather, it offers a structured theory of how self-understanding, interpersonal perception, and psychological growth may relate.

The model contains five major contributions:

1. A **three-layer architecture** linking direct experience, memory-based modeling, and reflective self-modeling.
2. A **six-part architecture of the self**: lived self, integrated self, shadow self, ideal self, self-image or ego, and projected self or mask.

3. A **mirror model** explaining how one person's perception of another can reveal information both about the observed person and the observer.
4. A **Composite Observer** concept describing the richer relational picture that emerges when two people reflect one another.
5. A **feedback-loop account of dissonance and growth**, in which lived experience either revises the self-model or is defensively resisted.

The whitepaper concludes that psychological growth can be understood as a progressive reduction of the gap between the person as lived, the person as represented internally, and the person as presented socially.

1. Purpose and Scope

The aim of this whitepaper is to articulate a coherent and understandable psychological framework that can be discussed, critiqued, and further developed by the psychology community.

The framework does **not** assume that every judgment of another person is projection. It does **not** reduce the person to pathology. It does **not** claim that social presentation is always false. And it does **not** assume access to a perfectly transparent "true self." Instead, it proposes a structured way of thinking about how different self-processes interact.

The intended audience includes psychologists, psychotherapists, scholars of selfhood, and educated readers interested in conceptual models of identity and personal growth.

2. Background Orientation

The framework resonates with several well-known psychological traditions while remaining distinct from each of them.

- From **humanistic psychology**, it inherits the idea that suffering often involves a gap between lived experience and self-representation.
- From **self-discrepancy theory**, it inherits the importance of tension between who a person is, who they think they are, and who they feel they should become.
- From **depth psychology**, it borrows the insight that some psychologically active material remains insufficiently recognized or integrated.

- From **symbolic interactionism** and later work on **reflected appraisal**, it inherits the idea that identity is partly shaped by the perceived gaze of others.
- From contemporary perspectives on **self-modeling**, it takes the idea that the self is not merely lived, but also represented, interpreted, defended, and revised.

The distinctive contribution of the present framework is to place these themes into one architecture centered on the **dual relation between lived experience and interpersonal reflection**.

3. The Three-Layer Model of Self and Experience

The foundation of the framework is a three-layer model that explains where selfhood emerges and why self-dissonance occurs.

3.1 Layer 1: Direct Experience

At the first layer, an observer encounters reality directly through multiple perceptual and affective channels: image, sound, bodily sensation, and feeling. This is the level of immediate experience.

At this layer, the self is not yet primarily a theory. It is something that appears through what is felt, done, wanted, feared, repeated, and endured in the flow of life. The **lived self** is rooted here.

3.2 Layer 2: Memory and the World-Model

At the second layer, the mind does more than receive experience: it compares present experience with memory and develops an internal model of how the world works. This model allows prediction and interpretation, but it is also subject to revision when new experience conflicts with it.

The key principle of this layer is the **feedback loop**:

- the model interprets experience,
- and experience challenges the model.

This feedback logic is central because it later applies not only to the external world but also to the self.

3.3 Layer 3: The Self-Model

At the third layer, the modeling function turns back upon the observer. The person develops a representation of who they are. This **self-model** includes the self-image or ego, ideals, recognized traits, disowned traits, and the persona shown to others.

This is where psychological conflict becomes especially meaningful. When lived experience contradicts the self-model, the psyche must either revise the model or defend it. Growth depends on the capacity for revision. Suffering often intensifies when an idealized or rigid self-image resists correction.

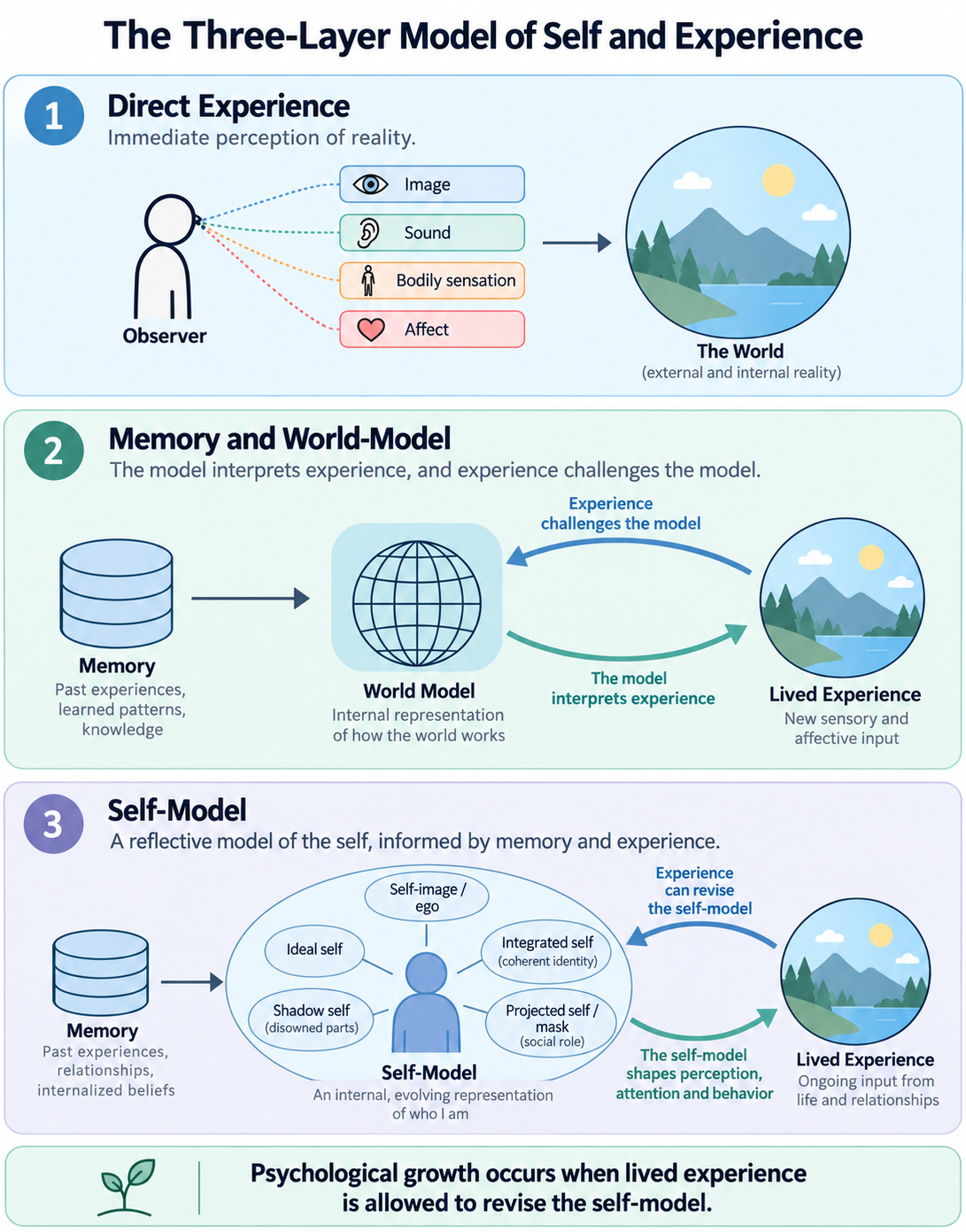


Figure 1. The three-layer model of self and experience.

4. The Architecture of the Self

Within the self-model, six components are especially important.

4.1 The Lived or True Self

The lived self refers to the recurring patterns that appear through experience: behaviour, emotion, needs, values, choices, and relational tendencies. It is the person as enacted in life rather than merely described in language.

4.2 The Integrated Self

The integrated self consists of aspects of the person that are consciously recognized and accepted as belonging to the self. Integration does not imply moral approval. A trait is integrated when it can be acknowledged without requiring denial or suppression.

4.3 The Shadow Self

The shadow self contains aspects of the lived self that remain denied, repressed, unrecognized, or excluded from conscious self-understanding. The shadow is not reducible to what is socially undesirable. It may include anger, envy, dependency, vulnerability, ambition, sensitivity, tenderness, or other qualities that are psychologically active but insufficiently integrated.

4.4 The Ideal Self

The ideal self represents the qualities a person values and wishes to embody. It gives direction to growth. However, the ideal self can distort identity when aspiration is confused with actuality. One of the framework's central claims is that suffering often arises when the self-image is shaped more by the ideal self than by the lived self.

4.5 The Self-Image or Ego

The self-image is the internal representation a person holds of who they believe they are. It is shaped by experience, memory, aspiration, feedback, and interpretation. In this framework, the ego is not treated as intrinsically pathological. It is necessary for coherence and continuity. Problems arise when it becomes rigid, overly defended, or overly idealized.

4.6 The Projected Self or Mask

The projected self is the version of the self that becomes socially visible. It is the persona that others encounter. In ordinary life, people often do not experience this as a separate mask; it simply feels like who they are. That is precisely why it is psychologically important. The socially presented self may be sincere and yet still remain partly misaligned with the lived self.



Figure 2. The architecture of the self.

5. Self-Dissonance, Misalignment, and Suffering

The framework explains psychological suffering partly through the idea of **misalignment**.

Misalignment occurs when there is a persistent gap between:

- the **lived self**,
- the **self-image**,
- and the **projected self**.

A person may wish to see themselves as calm, generous, selfless, rational, or independent, but life may repeatedly reveal fear, resentment, dependency, avoidance, or hostility. This contradiction produces **self-dissonance**.

Self-dissonance does not automatically lead to growth. It can produce:

- shame,
- defensiveness,
- denial,
- minimization,
- projection,
- rationalization,
- or persistent internal suffering.

In this framework, the **shadow** often emerges from failed updating. Experience reveals something about the person, but the self-image resists incorporating it. What is lived but not accepted remains psychologically active outside awareness.

6. The Mirror Between Two Persons

The framework becomes fully relational when two persons encounter one another. Each person brings a self-model into the interaction, and each perceives the other through their own psychological organization.

The central principle is the **duality of perspectives**:

- the way I perceive you reveals something about you,
- but it may also reveal something about me.

Three forms of perception are especially important.

6.1 Negative Reaction and Shadow Projection

When one person reacts strongly with dislike, irritation, or judgment toward another, the reaction may reveal something about the observer’s own shadow self. The framework does not claim this is always the case. But a powerful negative reaction can be psychologically informative, especially when it appears disproportionate or recurrent.

6.2 Positive Admiration and Aspirational Reflection

When one person strongly admires another, the admiration may reveal something about the observer’s ideal self—the qualities they value and wish to embody. At the same time, admiration usually identifies something real that is being expressed by the other person. The other’s projected self therefore becomes a surface onto which aspiration attaches.

6.3 Direct Perception

Not every perception is projection or aspiration. Sometimes we simply notice a real trait, skill, behaviour, or fact about another person. This safeguard is essential to preserve rigor. The model should not collapse into the claim that everything is secretly about the observer.

The same logic applies in both directions. Person A’s view of Person B reveals something about A and something about B, and Person B’s view of Person A does the same.

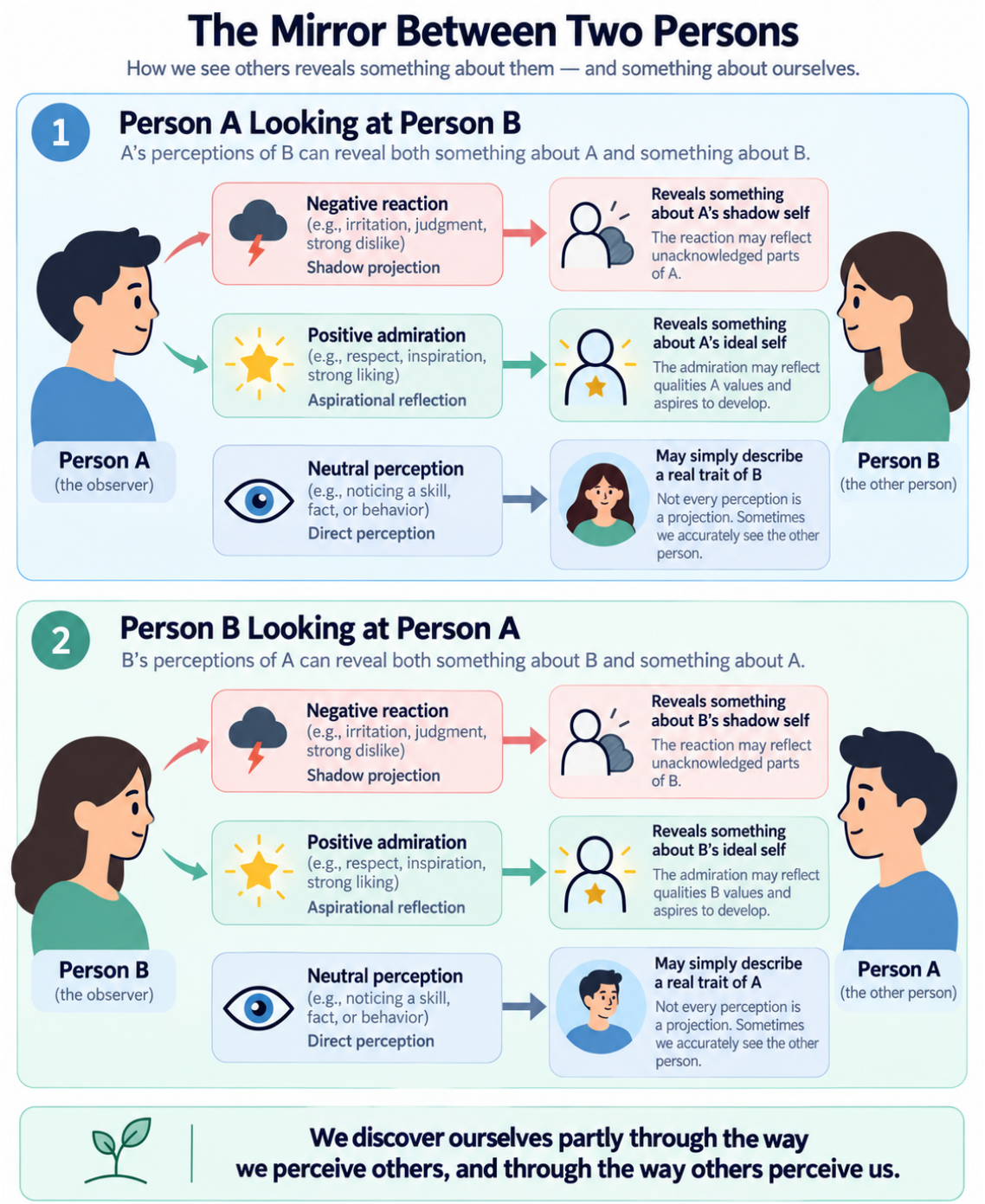


Figure 3. The mirror between two persons.

7. The Composite Observer

The concept of the **Composite Observer** is a distinctive contribution of the framework.

The Composite Observer is **not** an actual third person and not an all-seeing external judge. It is the richer relational picture that emerges when two people reflect one another.

When Person A looks at Person B:

- A's negative projections may reveal A's shadow self.
- A's admiration may reveal A's ideal self.
- What A admires often overlaps with qualities actually expressed by B's projected or lived self.

When Person B looks at Person A, the same structure appears in reverse.

The Composite Observer therefore emerges from the overlap of three elements in each person:

- the **shadow self**,
- the **ideal self**,
- the **projected self**.

A crucial overlap occurs when **one person's ideal self corresponds to qualities expressed by the other person's projected self**. Likewise, one person's shadow material may become visible through the negative charge generated by the other person's presentation.

The result is a relational field in which each person's perceptions simultaneously carry **self-information** and **other-information**.

8. The Feedback Loop Between Lived Experience and the Self-Model

The interpersonal mirror becomes especially important because it intensifies a more general process: the feedback loop between lived experience and the self-model.

The loop works as follows:

1. The person undergoes lived experience.
2. New experience challenges the current self-image.
3. The psyche can respond in one of two broad ways.

8.1 Defensive Protection

In one path, the psyche defends the established self-image. Contradictory evidence is minimized, denied, rationalized, or projected outward. The self-model remains rigid and the person retains a more idealized image of themselves, but growth is blocked.

8.2 Integrative Revision

In the other path, the person acknowledges the mismatch and allows revision. Shadow material becomes thinkable, the self-image expands, and the person becomes more aligned internally. This path does not eliminate discomfort, but it uses discomfort as information.

The revised self-model then influences future perception, attention, and behaviour. Growth therefore unfolds as an ongoing cycle rather than a one-time revelation.

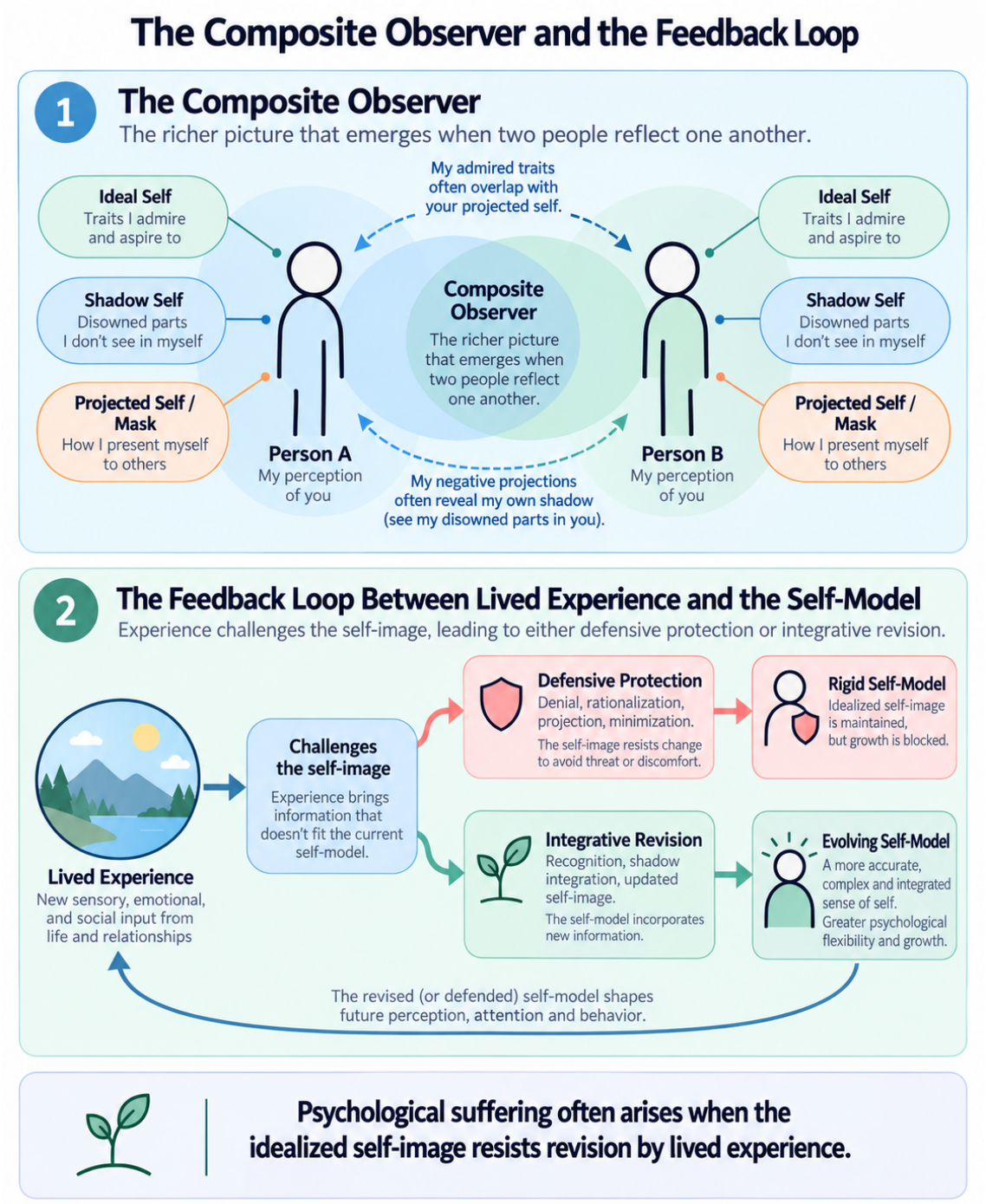


Figure 4. The composite observer and the feedback loop.

9. Psychological Growth in the Framework

Within this model, psychological growth can be defined as the **progressive reduction of the gap** between the lived self, the self-image, and the projected self.

Growth involves:

- recognizing dissonance,

- tolerating the discomfort of contradiction,
- distinguishing aspiration from actuality,
- becoming aware of shadow material,
- allowing the self-image to be revised,
- and presenting oneself more authentically in relationship.

The framework therefore places special emphasis on **sincerity**. Here sincerity does not simply mean telling the truth to others. It means allowing lived reality to modify the story one tells oneself about who one is.

10. Relevance to the Psychology Community

The Relational Self Framework may be of interest to the psychology community for at least four reasons.

10.1 It Integrates Several Existing Domains

The model creates a common structure linking self-concept, self-discrepancy, shadow material, reflected appraisal, and interpersonal feedback.

10.2 It Emphasizes Process Rather Than Static Traits

The framework is dynamic. It shows how selfhood evolves through feedback, revision, and relationships rather than treating personality as a fixed list of attributes.

10.3 It Clarifies the Role of Relationships in Self-Knowledge

The model gives interpersonal perception a central epistemic role. The self is not merely expressed in relationships; it is partially discovered through them.

10.4 It Generates Research Questions

The framework suggests testable questions, such as:

- Under what conditions does a strong negative reaction to another person correlate with disowned self-aspects?
- How does admiration differ when it primarily tracks the observer's ideal self versus when it primarily tracks appreciation of another person's real traits?
- What conditions make the self-image more flexible and revisable?
- How do specific relational contexts amplify or soften self-dissonance?

11. Limits and Safeguards

For the model to remain rigorous, several limits are essential.

First, **not every negative reaction is projection**. Second, **not every admiration is a clue to the ideal self**. Third, **the projected self is not automatically false**. Fourth, **the framework is conceptual rather than a validated clinical protocol**. Fifth, **it should not be used to over-interpret or pathologize ordinary social perception**.

These safeguards are part of the framework, not external objections to it. They protect the model from becoming unfalsifiable or reductive.

12. Conclusion

The Relational Self Framework proposes that selfhood is best understood as a dynamic relation among lived experience, conscious recognition, disowned material, aspiration, self-representation, and social presentation.

It further proposes that self-knowledge develops not only through introspection but also through the duality of perspectives that emerges between persons. From this interpersonal mirror arises the Composite Observer: a richer understanding produced by the overlap of shadow, ideal, and projected selves.

Psychological growth, in this model, is not the destruction of ego or persona. It is the **progressive alignment** of the self-model with lived reality and the increasingly authentic expression of that alignment in relationship.

In that sense, the framework offers a simple but far-reaching thesis:

we become more whole when lived experience is allowed to revise the self we believe ourselves to be, and when relationships are used not merely to defend identity, but to deepen it.

References for Orientation

The present whitepaper is conceptual. The following references are offered only as orientation points for readers who may wish to situate the framework relative to established traditions:

- Cooley, C. H. *Human Nature and the Social Order.*
- Higgins, E. T. Work on self-discrepancy theory.
- Jung, C. G. Work on the shadow and unconscious aspects of the psyche.
- Mead, G. H. Work on selfhood and the social other.
- Rogers, C. R. Work on congruence, self-concept, and lived experience.
- Contemporary research on reflected appraisal, self-concept clarity, and interpersonal feedback.